an ardent Buddhist after meeting the Buddhist monk Upagupta and propounded his Dharma. The only true conquest, he proclaimed, is the conquest of self and the conquest of men's hearts by the *dhamma* (Pali) or *dharma* (Sanskrit). He issued edicts, which were carved out in the rock.

There are 33 edicts, including 14 major rock edicts, 7 pillar edicts and 2 Kalinga edicts, apart from Minor Rock edicts and Minor Pillar inscriptions. They form the reliable sources to know about the Mauryan Empire, in particular the dharmic rule of Ashoka.



Ashoka Pillar, Allahabad

In one of his Kalinga edicts, he tells us his horror and sorrow over the deaths which the war and conquest caused. In yet another edict, he makes it known that Ashoka would not tolerate any longer the death or captivity of even hundredth or thousandth part of the number killed and made captive in Kalinga.

Ashoka's passion for protecting life extended to animals as well. Hospitals were constructed for them and animal sacrifice was forbidden. Ashoka sent his son Mahendra and his daughter Sanghamitra to Ceylon to spread his message of Dharma there. Ashoka died after ruling for 38 years.

Our national emblem with four lions is a replica of the Ashoka Pillar of Saranath.

Mauryan Administration

The Mauryan state in its early years undertook some measures that were positive for the development of society. The state raised taxes to finance a huge standing army and a vast bureaucracy. The Mauryans had evolved a very efficient system of governance. The king, as the head of the administration, was assisted by a council of ministers. There were *mahamatriyas*, who functioned as secretaries to the ministers. The person in charge of revenue and expenditure was *samaharta*. The empire was divided into four provinces and these provinces were administered by governors, who were usually princes or from the royal family.

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The district was under a *sthanika*, while *gopas* were in charge of five to ten villages. The municipal(Pataliputhra) administration was under a *nagaraka.* Six committees with five members each carried on their duties under him.

i. They were to take care of the foreigners.

ii. To register the birth and death of the citizens

iii. To look after trade and commerce,

iv. To supervise different manufactures

v. To collect excise duties and custom duties

Like the city or town administration, the military department was also managed by a board of 30 members, split into six committees, with five members in each of them. At the village level, there was *gramani*, whose responsibility was maintaining the boundaries, keeping the records of land and a census of population and livestock. In order to keep a vigil over the entire administration, including the conduct of officers, a well-knit spy system was evolved and put in place. Justice was administered through well-established courts in all major towns and cities. Punishment for crimes was severe.

DO YOU KNOW?

Chandragupta's minister Chanakya is credited with a book titled *Arthasastra*, which gives a detailed account of the Mauryan administration.

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